Congress party that was in power in Kerala, too, found it an opportunity to bring down K Karunakaran from the Chief Minister's chair. This they succeeded when A K Antony, then Oommen Chandy's leader, replaced Karunakaran in March 1995.

The false implication of inspector general of police Raman Srivastava in the case was part of the coup as the officer was believed to be close to Karunakaran. The CBI and the Supreme Court finally saw through these multiple game plans and acquitted all the accused. The CBI went to the extent of writing confidential letters to the union government and the Kerala government recommending action against the officers who implicated me and others in the case. That action is yet to be taken.

While the American game plan was specifically designed to stymie India's cryogenic programme, the timing of the ISRO spy case is significant also because of another ISRO milestone, the successful flight of the PSLV. It marked the coming of age of India's liquid propulsion system. For me it was the culmination of more than two decades of internal battles to bring in a liquid system into the heart of India's first satellite launch vehicle.

The first launch of PSLV (D1) on 20 September 1993 was a failure, but I was happy that the Viking engine that we so painstakingly developed had performed well. The second launch (PSLV-D2) was a textbook success. PSLV has had no failure since then, and it had thirty-five consecutively successful launches till June 2016. The first successful launch of PSLV was on 15 October 1994. Five days later, the Maldivian woman, Mariam Rasheeda was arrested. More than a month later, on 30 November they came for me.

The run-up to the PSLV launch was a period of uncertainty over some succession issues in ISRO. U R Rao, with whom I had an excellent rapport, was to retire in April 1994. Among the probable successors was Muthunayagam, my boss at the Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre. My experience as his deputy in LPSC had not been great. He was not amused by my proximity to the ISRO chairman right from Vikram Sarabhai, Satish Dhawan and now U R Rao. His inherent biases were not a secret; and these were to eventually cost his the chairman's post which Rao entrusted with R